

Chapter 131-5

//

Perhaps because it was near the sea, Haizhou City's winters always brought biting sea winds.

The humidity was very high, carrying a faint salty, briny smell.

But it was much better compared to summer.

Xu Qingzhu sat by the window holding a cup of coffee with both hands. Sally and Lin Luoxi were bickering as usual, and as usual, it ended with Sally's defeat.

The weather had turned cold these past few days, and Xu Qingzhu had already put on a turtleneck sweater. Her long hair draped over her shoulders, making her look quiet and warm.

There was a faint red lip mark on the coffee cup. Xu Qingzhu took a light sip of the steaming coffee, and when she set down the cup, her fingernail gently rubbed across the cup's surface, wiping away that touch of red.

She lowered her eyes, and Sally and Lin Luoxi immediately fell quiet.

Sally couldn't help herself: "Blanche, how much longer are you going to stay gloomy? When Liang Shi wakes up and sees you like this, she'll scold us."

Xu Qingzhu's brows furrowed slightly, ripples flowing in her eyes. The corners of her lips gently curved upward into a beautiful arc. "Why would she scold you?"

"You've gotten thinner." Sally said. "She'll definitely say we didn't take good care of you."

Lin Luoxi agreed. "That's hard to say for sure."

Xu Qingzhu spoke softly, her gaze sweeping toward the crowd outside the window, where people strolled past in twos and threes as if taking a leisurely walk.

Her slender, pale hand rested lightly on the light-colored wooden table, her eyelashes fluttering gently as she said in a low voice: "I've actually been eating quite a lot lately."

"Eating and then throwing up?" Lin Luoxi asked. "Is there something wrong with your stomach?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "No, I only threw up that one time."

Last time, she had gone with Lin Luoxi and the others to eat rice noodles outside school, and she threw up on the way back.

No fever, no cold.

She simply threw up after eating too much.

Lin Luoxi had thought this was normal for her.

In fact, Xu Qingzhu had only experienced it that once. It was because they had mentioned Liang Shi during the meal, and she had eaten too much trying to gain some weight. Combined with the bumpy road and Sally's reckless driving, she couldn't hold it in.

The rest of the time, she had been eating well and sleeping well.

Liang Shi had been in a coma for over half a month. Apart from being in a bad mood, everything else was fine.

Work was even busier.

Su Zhe intended to let her get involved in Haiwei's business, and they were working on a collaborative winter collection.

The increasingly busy career allowed her to temporarily forget about Liang Shi's coma.

But memories related to Liang Shi would always surface unexpectedly.

Ever since Sun Chengcheng had conveyed that message to her, the words she whispered most often while sitting by the hospital bed were: "Is it nice over there? Are you happy?"

If Liang Shi could be happy, then she would accept it.

During these long, long nights, sleeping alone and unable to rest, she inevitably thought a lot.

She had imagined Liang Shi's world over and over in her mind.

But she could never quite grasp it.

Without having seen it with her own eyes, how could she know what kind of prosperity existed on her side?

Lin Luoxi noticed her mind wandering and waved a hand in front of her eyes. "Then drink less coffee."

Only then did Xu Qingzhu's scattered thoughts slowly gather. She pressed her lips together in a light smile. "Got it."

"Coffee is only suitable for people like Sally who would die if they didn't sleep ten hours a day." While comforting Xu Qingzhu, Lin Luoxi didn't forget to throw shade at her own girlfriend, drawing Sally's resentment. But with one look from Lin Luoxi, Sally immediately became as quiet as a quail.

Lin Luoxi said: "You already have insomnia, and you're still drinking coffee. Can you even sleep at night?"

"It's okay." Xu Qingzhu said. "I can sleep over seven hours every night now."

It was just that the light sleep state lasted quite a while, and she always slept on and off.

Seeing her like this, Lin Luoxi could only sigh helplessly. There wasn't much she could do.

Instead, it was Sally who said: "Don't you have a Taoist temple around here? Should we go pray tomorrow? I heard it's very effective. Or a Buddhist temple would work too."

Lin Luoxi: ".....You're certainly not picky."

Sally flipped her hair: "Whoever can bless us, we'll believe in them."

Lin Luoxi: "....."

She didn't know if Sally had learned the essence of Chinese people's approach to praying to gods, or if people all over the world were like this.

When trouble arose, everyone had to pray—as long as one of them worked, that was enough.

When nothing was wrong, they only believed in themselves and would tell others that all of that was superstition.

But Lin Luoxi thought this was also a solution.

Even if praying to gods and Buddhas didn't work, at least it would count as taking Xu Qingzhu for a stroll up the mountain.

It was just that in winter, there wasn't much good scenery along the way—far inferior to summer.

Coastal cities' winters and summers each had their own advantages.

"How about we go to Yunfeng Mountain tomorrow?" Lin Luoxi said. "Last year, a friend of mine went there to pray, and she got pregnant this year."

Xu Qingzhu was surprised. "Yunfeng Mountain doesn't handle childbirth matters, does it? It's not like it has Songzi Guanyin.¹"

"Sincerity makes it effective." Lin Luoxi said. "They're already immortals. What can't they do?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Lin Luoxi continued: "Only us mortals are powerless."

Xu Qingzhu was somewhat persuaded. After a moment of silence, she laughed softly. "That's true."

There was still a hint of bitterness in that laugh.

Lunch break ended, and they left the coffee shop together.

Sally shielded her eyes with her hand and looked up at the cold sun in the sky.

The sky was azure blue—not a very clear azure, with a few white clouds floating in it.

¹ **Songzi Guanyin (送子菩薩/送子觀音):** Literally "Child-Sending Guanyin," this is a form of the Bodhisattva Guanyin (Avalokiteśvara) specifically associated with fertility and childbirth. Women who wish to conceive often pray to this deity. The point being made is that Yunfeng Mountain's temple doesn't specifically house a fertility deity.